Yousef Khudher

Cybersecurity Expert | Purple Team Specialist | Security Operations Leader

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Languages: Arabic (Native), English (Professional Working Proficiency)

PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

Purple Team specialist and co-founder with a decade of hands-on technical work since 2016, securing a national-scale environment of 1,000+ local and public-facing systems, 100+ servers, thousands of endpoints, and millions of end users. Cut SOC false positives from 60% to 15% through systematic detection tuning, and delivered 341+ red team and blue team assessment reports to date, bridging adversary simulation with detection engineering against the MITRE ATT&CK framework. Holder of all 14 OffSec certifications, a combination held by very few professionals globally, plus 36 total industry certifications including ISO/IEC 27001 and ISO/IEC 27701 Lead Auditor. Ranked 1st in Iraq and 19th globally at HTB Cyber Apocalypse 2025 among 18,000+ players. Discovered and responsibly disclosed 570+ vulnerabilities across HackerOne and global bug bounty platforms, plus 100+ more under contracted security engagements with Iraqi companies. Author of open-source offensive and defensive security tooling in Python, C, and C# — custom scanners that cut reconnaissance on assessments from two days to roughly three hours.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Private Company (Confidential)
Iraq | 2025 – Present | Full-time

Security Operations Leader, Red Team — Co-Founder
May 2026 – Present

- Co-founded the venture and lead a team of 4–5 security engineers, directing red team strategy and full-scope adversary emulation engagements.
- Plan and execute red team operations covering initial access, privilege escalation, lateral movement, and post-exploitation across enterprise environments.
- Build and maintain offensive tooling and attack infrastructure including C2 frameworks, redirectors, and custom payloads for OPSEC-safe operations.
- Identified and responsibly disclosed 100+ vulnerabilities under contracted security engagements with Iraqi companies, assessing production applications including Mantaqty (Codion Solutions), Linkchi for Software Solutions, FOR YOU MARKET, and Shaghlaty.
- Lead client-facing offensive engagements and present findings and remediation roadmaps to executive stakeholders.

Application Security Specialist / Penetration Tester / Testing Team Leader
2025 – Present

- Lead application security engagements assessing web and mobile applications for OWASP Top 10 and business logic vulnerabilities.
- Coordinate test coverage across the team, manage engagement timelines, and deliver findings to stakeholders.
- Built custom scanning tooling that cut reconnaissance time per assessment from two days to roughly three hours, letting the team cover more targets within the same engagement window.

Cybersecurity Specialist, Purple Team · SOC Engineer
Ministry of Interior, Iraq | December 2024 – Present | Full-time

- Secure a national-scale environment spanning 1,000+ local and public-facing systems, 100+ servers, thousands of endpoints, and millions of end users.
- Reduced SOC false positive rate from 60% to 15% through systematic detection tuning, sharply cutting analyst alert fatigue and freeing capacity for genuine threats.
- Delivered 341+ red team and blue team assessment reports to date, covering offensive findings, detection gap analysis, and remediation guidance.
- Operate as SOC engineer and cross-layer security advisor across network, endpoint, application, and infrastructure defense.
- Bridge Red and Blue Team operations, validating detection coverage against the MITRE ATT&CK framework through adversary simulation.
- Perform threat hunting and incident response using ELK SIEM; review and report vulnerability scan findings across the estate.
- Coordinate compliance audit evidence aligned with ISO/IEC 27001 and COBIT frameworks.

Red Team Penetration Tester
Ministry of Interior, Iraq (same employer) | 2025 – April 2026 | 8 months

- Conducted red team engagements and offensive penetration tests against enterprise infrastructure and applications, emulating real-world adversary tradecraft.
- Fed offensive findings directly into purple team detection-tuning work, closing the loop between attack and defense.

Penetration Tester
AMC, Iraq | May 2024 – January 2025 | 9 months

- Conducted internal and external penetration tests across enterprise systems and networks.
- Developed custom security tooling in Python and C++ to automate vulnerability discovery.

SOC Engineer
AMC, Iraq | November 2023 – April 2024 | Full-time

- Monitored security events, triaged alerts, and performed incident response using SIEM tooling.
- Developed detection playbooks to standardize and accelerate analyst response.

Independent Security Consultant and Application Developer
Self-employed | 2018 – Present

- Advise companies across Iraq and the MENA region on security posture, control gaps, and governance (ISO/IEC 27001, ISO/IEC 27701, PCI-DSS, NIST), delivering vulnerability assessments and penetration tests with formal reports.
- Design and build websites and custom software for regional clients with security hardening built in from the start.
- Develop bespoke automation tooling that absorbs repetitive assessment work, keeping delivery consistent without adding headcount.

Network Administrator and Network Engineer
Almadar ISP / Freelance, Iraq | 2022 – 2023

- Administered live ISP production network infrastructure: routing, switching, DNS/ARP/TCP-IP, and firewall configuration, alongside call-center IT support.

Cybersecurity Competition Judge and Supervisor
Ministry of Interior and Ministry of Communications, Iraq | 2024 – 2025 | Part-time

- Supervised and judged three national-level cybersecurity competitions on behalf of Iraqi government ministries: two for the Ministry of Interior (2024–2025) and one for the Ministry of Communications (2025).

CTF Supervisor, National Internship Program
MOI Cybersecurity Directorate, Iraq | 2024 – 2025

- Designed and supervised a nationwide internship CTF program with approximately 500 participating students from across Iraq.

Bug Bounty Security Researcher
HackerOne and Regional Platforms, Independent | 2022 – Present

- Discovered and responsibly disclosed 570+ vulnerabilities ranging from Critical to Medium severity across global bug bounty programs.
- Assessed web applications, APIs, and network infrastructure; delivered detailed proof-of-concept reports with remediation guidance.

Academic Security Project Supervisor and Research Assistant
North Technical University and University of Mosul, Iraq | 2019 – Present | Part-time

- Designed and supervised 100+ Bachelor's, Master's, and PhD projects in network security and cybersecurity, covering IDS/IPS, secure communications, and Arduino/Raspberry Pi hardware security with custom PCB design; all achieved Excellent grades.
- Mentor learners and junior engineers across UX/UI, databases, and system optimization; perform reverse engineering and vulnerability testing on APIs and applications as part of mentoring engagements (2016 – Present).

EARLIER EXPERIENCE

IT Specialist to Senior Data Entry Clerk, AMC, Iraq (2021–2023) — Processed 5,000+ records daily into CRM/ERP at 99% accuracy; created standardized templates that improved team productivity 20% and reduced data errors 10%; mentored 4 new clerks and was promoted for exceeding quality targets.

Freelance Software and Web Development, Self-employed (2016–2021) — Built production mobile applications in the **Flutter** framework for local companies and ran a website-development-as-a-service business delivering **WordPress** sites and custom software for retail and small companies; performed bug bounty penetration testing for local companies and built custom pentest tooling; developed Minecraft mods and shader packs in Java.

OPEN SOURCE SECURITY TOOLING

The three scanners below are used in live engagements and together cut reconnaissance from roughly two days of manual probing to about three hours.

SecureIntake (C#, Avalonia) — Cross-platform defensive GUI for safe triage of inbound files. Enforces allow-lists, inspects PDF and OOXML for risky features, runs fail-closed AV scanning (ClamAV/Defender), AES-GCM encrypts accepted output, and emits JSON audit logs tagged to MITRE ATT&CK.

Open-RedirIN (Python) — Detection tool for open redirect vulnerabilities in web applications.

lfi-hammer (Python) — Local File Inclusion scanner for real-world web targets.

Wadvancescanner (Python) — Web application scanner performing port discovery, enumeration, and vulnerability surfacing.

Advanced-Firewall, endpoint-firewall, IFire (Python, C) — Endpoint and network firewall tooling defending against DDoS, DNS spoofing, and ARP spoofing, with live rule management.

TECHNICAL SKILLS

Security Operations: Purple Team Operations, Adversary Emulation, Penetration Testing, Red Team, Blue Team, Threat Hunting, Incident Response, Vulnerability Management, SIEM (ELK, Splunk), SOC Operations, Malware Analysis

Frameworks and Standards: MITRE ATT&CK, NIST CSF, ISO/IEC 27001, ISO/IEC 27701, COBIT, OWASP, PTES, GDPR, PCI-DSS

Offensive Security: Web Application Exploitation, LFI, SSRF, Open Redirect, Active Directory Attacks, Wireless Attacks, Post-Exploitation, Lateral Movement, Privilege Escalation

Cloud and Infrastructure: AWS, Azure, GCP, Docker, Kubernetes, IAM Exploitation, CI/CD Pipeline Attacks, IaC Misconfiguration, Fortinet, Cisco, MikroTik

Tools: Burp Suite, Metasploit, Nmap, Nessus, Wireshark, Cobalt Strike, BloodHound, Impacket, SQLMap

Programming: Python, Bash, PowerShell, C, C++, C#, Dart (Flutter), Java, JavaScript

CERTIFICATIONS (36 TOTAL)

Offensive Security (OffSec), all 14: OSCE3, OSCP+, OSCP, OSEP, OSWE, OSED, OSWP, OSWA, OSDA, OSTH, OSIR, KLCP, OSCC-SJD, OSCC-SEC

CyberWarfare Labs: CRTA, MCRTA, MCBTA, DO-RTA, CRT-ID, CRTOM

Governance and Compliance: ISO/IEC 27001:2022 Lead Auditor, ISO/IEC 27701:2025 Lead Auditor

Network and Infrastructure: Cisco CCNA, Cisco CCNP, MikroTik MTCNA, Fortinet NSE3, Fortinet FCA, Aviatrix MCNA

Blue Team and SOC: OffSec SOC100 (100% score), eLearnSecurity eCIR, CSEDP, CNSP

EDUCATION

Bachelor of Engineering, Computer Engineering
University of Mosul, Iraq

- Final-year project: Intrusion Detection System (IDS) monitoring live network traffic to detect ARP spoofing, flooding, and TCP/TFTP anomalies using ML-enhanced algorithms. Graduated with Excellent grade.

CTF AND COMPETITION ACHIEVEMENTS

1st in Iraq, 19th Globally — HTB Cyber Apocalypse 2025, 18,000+ players worldwide, competed solo

52nd of 796 teams — Global Cyber Skills Benchmark CTF 2025, 77 of 103 challenges, 36,675 points (HackTheBox)

51st of 663 RITSEC CTF • **55th of 3,175** EC-Council Hackerverse • **Top 61 of 1,668** DownUnderCTF 6 • **Top Rank** VishwaCTF 2026